

GERMANY'S FIRST ACES

MAX IMMELMANN (1890–1916) and Oswald Boelcke (1891–1916) were members of Flight Section 62 stationed at Douai, France, in August 1915. They were among the first pilots issued with the Fokker Eindecker, and they used it to deadly effect. As their victories mounted, they were trumpeted in German propaganda as examples of fearless devotion to the Fatherland. They were courted by the aristocracy, lauded by journalists, and deluged with fan mail.

Immelmann, a fitness fanatic and teetotaler, was killed in June 1916, probably by a faulty interrupter gear in his Eindecker – causing him to blow off his own propeller. His legacy was a tricky maneuver, the Immelmann turn, which consisted of pulling upward out of an attacking dive, performing a half-roll, and dropping on the enemy from above a second time.



PENETRATING STARE

People who met Boelcke were struck by the intensity of his gaze. As squadron leader, he trained many of Germany's greatest fliers.

THE EAGLE OF LILLE

Max Immelmann's death was commemorated in a variety of ways, including this specially composed march for the piano dedicated to "the memory of our flying hero."



Of the two, Boelcke was the more attractive and the more important; he was highly intelligent – a born leader and educator. He successfully argued for the grouping of hand-picked pilots in fighter squadrons, or *Jagdstaffeln*. As the leader of the first of these, Jasta 2, he passed on his knowledge to many of Germany's greatest fliers, including Manfred von Richthofen. Boelcke also set out the principles of air combat – known as Boelcke's Dicta – that were taught to all German pilots. He said, among other things, that pilots should attack from behind and out of the sun; fire only at close range; and when attacked from above, turn to face the enemy instead of trying to escape. In the fall of 1916, Jasta 2 was thrown into the intense air combats over the Somme. In two months, Boelcke downed 21 Allied aircraft, to give him a total of 40 victories. On October 28, during a fierce dogfight, he collided with one of his own colleagues and spiraled to earth, fatally fracturing his skull.

THE BLUE MAX

The Pour le Mérite was the highest German military decoration. The British nicknamed it the "Blue Max" after the first airman to win it, Max Immelmann.



SECTION 62

Flight Section 62 at Douai, France, in January 1916, including Boelcke (front, fourth from left) and Immelmann (front, third from right). German airmen were infused with a formal military discipline that contrasted strongly with the individualism of French elite pilots.



masculine virtues of physical courage, skillful aggression, chivalry, and noble sacrifice.

Britain's prime minister David Lloyd George told a wartime audience that airmen were "the knighthood of the war, without fear and without reproach." Airmen were by no means immune to this elevated view of their own activities. There are many recorded instances of self-consciously chivalrous behavior – for example, pilots who declined to finish off a brave and skillful enemy whose gun had jammed. Gestures of respect for the enemy were common. When the German ace Oswald Boelcke was killed in 1916, British fliers dropped a wreath at his burial site inscribed to "the memory of Captain Boelcke, our brave and chivalrous foe." But gestures of that kind were

only a veneer on the ruthlessness of aerial warfare. The aces did not spend much time fighting aerial duels with skillful opponents, choosing to prey on lone reconnaissance aircraft instead. During dogfights they picked on the least experienced pilots, exploiting their errors for an easy kill. Top British ace Edward "Mick" Mannock once chanced upon six German aircraft on a training-school flight; he shot down the instructor and then picked off the five defenseless pupils one by one.

Souvenir hunting

Mannock was noted for his hatred of Germans and contempt for gestures of chivalry – his comment on the death of Germany's most